

Taking Broadband To The Skies

Radio scientists in the UK have demonstrated the first air-to-ground 'mesh broadband' connection. A microlight plane established a broadband connection with the South Witham mesh, at an altitude of 2,000 feet. Voice and data traffic was sent over the link.



Cell Phones As Bar-code Scanners!

New York inventor Bruce Hodge and his partner have created technology that allows people to comparison-shop with their cell phones. In early February in New York, he demonstrated it by waving his cell over a bar code: the phone listed the closest places to buy the item, and the cost at each retailer.



Escape

FIVE FEET UNDER

Talk To The Dead

We don't know what exactly to call this—a gadget? A service? An idea? Whatever you call it, Jürgen Bröther's 'invention' allows you to listen to the sound of grave soil. Seriously, it is supposed to enable a link to the body of the deceased—useful if one couldn't attend the funeral.

The German innovator's offering, the TelefonEngel or 'Phone Angel', consists of three items in a box—a mobile phone, a high-power battery, and a small loudspeaker, all in a waterproof container the size of an average shoe box. The loved ones of the deceased are supposed to bury this kit at the grave, keeping it 12 inches above the coffin.

Anyone can then phone in, and here's where the Phone Angel kicks in. You get to say whatever you



Jürgen Bröther with his invention

want, and it will be faithfully played back through the speaker—and what you get to listen to is, well, nothing, since the deceased is, well, dead.

One is tempted to say at this point, "So this is progress? Is this what technology is getting us to?" and so on... but we'll let that pass.

One also wonders what would happen to someone if he or she called and actually got a response from the other end...

IMMORAL NET USE

Cyber-café Crackdown In China

China has long had an anti-cyber-café agenda, and every now and then, we see reports about what the government has been doing to implement its stance. It has recently emerged that Chinese authorities closed down 12,575 cyber-café in the last few months of 2004.

According to the official Xinhua news agency, most of these close-downs happened because the cafés were "operating illegally."

And what exactly was illegal about the cafés' operations? It turns out that they were too close to schools. Chinese Internet cafés are supposed to operate under a set of strict guidelines, and many

UNUSABLE!



<http://calcutta.citynews.com/>

"Calcutta, India Photo Classifieds and Bargain Provincewide Ads". A little cryptic? The layout is deliciously terrible, with overlapping text, and links that seem to have no business being there. What are "free chats" doing on a classifieds site? What is a "Provincewide Ad"? And most intriguing, what are "Biggerads"?

The real fun begins when you dig a little deeper. Click on the 'Employment & Help Wanted' link. There's an ad from Brooklyn, one from Aberdeen, Scotland, one from San Jose, and one from Tokyo—"Come and work at the top strip clubs in Tokyo."

Click on 'Baby sitters', and you get the same ad from San Jose, and one saying 'Work At Home While Nurturing Your Kids!' Clicking on 'Education' takes you to the same San Jose ad (which, incidentally, is about boosting the power of your cable connection), as well as a link that says 'Protect Your Child From Abduction!' The list goes on—clicking on 'Motorcycles' takes you to ads that purport to help you track your car 24/7, and so on.

Hilarious navigation. With not a word about Calcutta, Kolkata, or, for that matter, even India.

Win!

My Desktop

Think you have the most beautiful, most innovative desktop around? Send it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com, and Digit will publish the most eye-catching of them each month.

The winner receives a copy of **UNIX for Programmers and Users, Third Edition**

By Graham Glass and King Ables, published by Pearson Education
This month's winner is Ranadeb Ray, Mumbai



Ranadeb Ray's desktop has really been customised beautifully; way to go Ranadeb
Sent in by Ranadeb Ray, Mumbai